

Tableau Actions and Stories — Notes

1. Tableau Actions

A **Tableau Action** is an interactive feature that allows a user's interaction with one visualization to affect another visualization, worksheet, dashboard, or related object.

Actions make Tableau dashboards more **interactive and dynamic**.

Common types of Tableau Actions include:

- Filter Action
- Highlight Action
- URL Action
- Go to Sheet Action
- Parameter Action
- Set Action

This section focuses on **Filter Action** and **Highlight Action**.

2. Filter Action

Definition

A **Filter Action** allows a selection made in one view to filter the data displayed in another view.

In simple terms:

Filter Action = Show only the data related to the selected value.

For example, selecting a particular **Region** can cause other visualizations to display data only for that Region.

Key characteristics

- Filters data in the target view.
- Unrelated data may be removed from the view.
- The source visualization controls the filtering.
- Useful for detailed analysis and drill-down.
- Makes dashboards interactive.

Basic structure

Source View → Selection → Target View → Filtered Data

3. Components of a Filter Action

Source Sheet

The visualization where the user makes a selection.

Target Sheet

The visualization that is affected by the selection.

Run Action On

Determines how the action is triggered.

Common options include:

- **Select** — action occurs when a mark is selected.
- **Hover** — action occurs when the cursor is placed over a mark.
- **Menu** — action is accessed through the menu associated with the mark.

Clearing the Selection

This determines what happens when the user removes the selection.

Common options include:

- Show all values
- Exclude all values
- Keep filtered values

4. Highlight Action

Definition

A **Highlight Action** emphasizes related marks in one or more visualizations based on a user's selection.

In simple terms:

Highlight Action = Make related data stand out without filtering it out.

Unlike a Filter Action, a Highlight Action does not primarily remove unrelated data. Instead, it visually emphasizes the relevant marks.

Key characteristics

- Highlights related data.
- Other data remains visible.
- Useful for comparison.
- Helps users identify relationships between visualizations.
- Makes important data points easier to notice.

5. Filter Action vs Highlight Action

Feature	Filter Action	Highlight Action
Purpose	Filters data	Emphasizes data
Unrelated data	May disappear	Remains visible
Main effect	Changes what is displayed	Changes what is emphasized
Best suited for	Detailed investigation	Comparison and pattern recognition
User experience	Focuses on selected data	Draws attention to selected data

Easy way to remember

Filter = Remove the unrelated data.

Highlight = Emphasize the related data.

6. Tableau Stories

Definition

A **Tableau Story** is a sequence of visualizations or dashboards arranged in a logical order to communicate insights from data.

A Story helps transform individual visualizations into a **narrative**.

The purpose of a Tableau Story is to guide the audience through an analysis and communicate the important findings.

7. Story Point

A **Story Point** is an individual stage of a Tableau Story.

Each Story Point can contain:

- A worksheet
- A dashboard
- A visualization
- A combination of views

Multiple Story Points are arranged sequentially to create the complete Story.

Structure

Story Point 1 → Story Point 2 → Story Point 3 → Story Point 4

Each point can communicate a different aspect of the analysis.

8. Tableau Story Structure

A well-designed data story generally follows a logical sequence:

1. Introduction

Provides an overview of the subject or business question.

2. Exploration

Presents important patterns and trends in the data.

3. Analysis

Examines the factors contributing to those patterns.

4. Insight

Communicates the significant findings.

5. Conclusion

Summarizes the key findings and, where appropriate, presents recommendations.

9. Dashboard vs Story

Dashboard	Story
Combines multiple visualizations into one view	Combines multiple views into a sequence
Designed mainly for exploration and monitoring	Designed mainly for communication and presentation
Allows users to explore different aspects of data	Guides users through a logical narrative
Multiple charts are visible together	Different Story Points are viewed sequentially
Focuses on interactive analysis	Focuses on communicating insights

Simple distinction

Dashboard = Explore the data
Story = Explain the data

10. Benefits of Tableau Stories

Tableau Stories can help to:

- Present data in a logical sequence.
 - Communicate complex findings clearly.
 - Guide an audience through an analysis.
 - Connect multiple visualizations.
 - Emphasize important insights.
 - Support data-driven decision-making.
 - Convert data analysis into a meaningful narrative.
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11. Characteristics of an Effective Tableau Story

A good Tableau Story should have:

Clear objective

The audience should understand what the analysis is trying to explain.

Logical sequence

Story Points should follow a meaningful order.

Relevant visualizations

Only visualizations that contribute to the message should be included.

Clear insights

The important findings should be easy to understand.

Consistency

Titles, terminology, formatting, and visual design should remain consistent.

Strong conclusion

The Story should end with a clear summary of the key findings.

12. Key Terms

Term	Meaning
Action	An interaction that causes a change in a Tableau view
Filter Action	Filters a target view based on a selection
Highlight Action	Emphasizes related marks
Source Sheet	The sheet where the interaction originates
Target Sheet	The sheet affected by the action
Story	A sequence of views used to communicate insights
Story Point	One stage of a Tableau Story
Dashboard	A collection of multiple visualizations in one view

13. Quick Revision

Filter Action

Selection → Filtering → Focused Data

Highlight Action

Selection → Emphasis → Related Data Stands Out

Tableau Story

Visualization → Story Points → Narrative → Insight

Three important statements

Filter Action changes what data is displayed.

Highlight Action changes what data gets attention.

Story organizes visualizations into a logical narrative.